

Beyond Morality: Nietzsche's Non-Prescriptive Project

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While a typical morality book starts off from first principles and reaches a set of morals, Nietzsche begins with morals and deconstructs them. On an initial read, it seems that Nietzsche wants to advocate for master, as opposed to slave, morality. This paper follows the questions that go in the opposite direction, questions which unravel rather than build to the point that there is no clear Nietzschean morality.

Nietzsche's moral project is not normative in its essence; it is about calling morality itself into question. First comes the realization that in contemporary society there exist value judgments which have been taken as truths: "one has taken the *value* of these 'values' as given, as factual, as beyond all question" (Preface, 6). It is common to deem an action valuable because it was good; yet, it is rare that people wonder what about the good itself is valuable. From this arises a set of questions: "under what conditions did man devise these value judgments good and evil? *And what value do they themselves possess?*" (Preface, 3). The first question asks for a historical, genealogical account; i.e. what context gave rise to the meaning of good and evil we have today? The second question hopes to find a value in the value judgments. Nietzsche continues: "have [these value judgments] hitherto hindered or furthered human prosperity?" (Preface 3). Here seems to lie a standard to which Nietzsche is holding morality accountable. Instead of morality being rationally correct, he wonders whether value judgments are encouraging humanity towards prosperity or pushing it back. Nevertheless, a reader may ask, why is prosperity itself valuable? More is needed to answer this question.

If Nietzsche believes that some values have value in themselves, then he must also hold some sort of *a priori* argument on what is valuable in and of itself. While Nietzsche does attach qualities to values, he does not claim that those qualifications are *a priori* (regardless of experience): “let us be on guard against the dangerous old conceptual fiction that posited a ‘pure, will-less, painless, time-less knowing subject’”(III, 12). Nietzsche claims that to think there are atemporal truths is not only nonsense, but dangerous nonsense. It is impossible to detach our will, our experience, our context, from the subject of examination. Hence, saying that any value (even prosperity) has value without any doubt is nonsense. Recalling the previous question, it seems Nietzsche is contradicting himself in saying that there is no way to claim that prosperity is *a priori* valuable. However, we must ask ourselves if Nietzsche is making such a claim at all!

For Nietzsche, it is impossible to make a claim that is not perspectival; nothing is in and of itself. When it comes to defending why there is no “knowledge in itself”, Nietzsche argues that, “there is *only* a perspective seeing, *only* a perspective ‘knowing’”(III, 12). The two phrases set up seeing and knowing as parallel activities. It is not the case that seeing is passive; Nietzsche mentions the “active and interpreting forces, through which alone seeing becomes seeing *something*”(III, 12). If seeing were passive, a mere reception of images, it would be impossible to recognize things. A chair would not be a chair, it would be an amalgamation of perceptions, it would not be something. Just like seeing carries an interpretative force, knowing does too. In the same way it is nonsense to say that it requires no interpretation to say that that is a chair, it is nonsense to say that any claim is separate from a perspectival interpretation. Hence, there is no *a priori* necessary value, just values that arise from interpretative perspectives.

This does not mean that Nietzsche argues that no claim is more accurate than another. Quite the opposite is true: “the *more* affects we allow to speak about one thing, the *more* eyes,

different eyes, we can use to observe one thing, the more complete will our ‘concept’ of this thing, our ‘objectivity’, be (III, 12)”. The attention to “more” and “different” eyes explains the process of contrasting distinct notions of good in order to question the universality of good and evil. Consider this: imagine a group of people all agree that what is in front of them is a bed. Now, a group of foreigners says that it is not a bed, for them, it is more of a couch since they sleep on the floor. Their perspectives clash, but their interaction can reveal something deeper about what a bed is. This is the “‘objectivity’” Nietzsche mentions in quotations: this method (perspectivism) does not reach a transcendent concept, but one grounded on shared perspectives. Returning to the previous question, to ask why Nietzsche values prosperity might be a misguided question since in our interpretation as readers we too attach value to prosperity. Thus, to set prosperity as a standard is not a universal claim; rather, a perspectival agreement between Nietzsche and the reader.

Applying this perspectivism to morality, Nietzsche subverts a typical, contemporary notion of good. Recalling the previous bed/couch example, perspectivism makes it so that if someone came into the room and said that the object was a hammock, there would have to be some serious thought of whether that person is lying, or if there is something much more profound at play. It sounds ridiculous to say, yet, is that not similar to when Nietzsche asks, “what if a symptom of regression were inherent in the ‘good,’ likewise a danger, a seduction, a poison, a narcotic, through which the present was possibly living at the expense of the future?” (Preface, 6). That what we took to be “good” is actually harmful, is that not to hear someone point at the “bed” and say it is a hammock? That it is actually the “good”, and not necessarily the “evil”, which is leading humanity downwards instead of upwards. The phrase “living at the expense of the future” clarifies the deceit that the “good” of today would lead to more “good” in

the future. Hearing this, it is easy to conclude that Nietzsche wants all of us to become “evil” since the “good” is not what we thought it was; right?

Since value-judgments arise from their context, morality is not to be taken as a guide, rather, as a justification. As part of the questions that guide Nietzsche, he asks: “are [good and evil] a sign of distress, of impoverishment, of the degeneration of life? Or is there revealed in them, on the contrary, the plenitude, force, and will of life, its courage, certainty, future?” (Preface, 3). For Nietzsche, good and evil (morality) are signs of certain conditions of life. It is not the case that good and evil precede society such that distress can be understood as a deviation from goodness. First comes a physiological state and then a moral system arises out of it. For instance, Nietzsche argues:

The judgment ‘good’ did *not* originate with those to whom ‘goodness’ was shown! Rather it was ‘the good’ themselves, that is to say, the noble, powerful, high-stationed and highminded, who felt and established themselves and their actions as good, that is of the first rank, in contradistinction to all the low, low-minded, common and plebeian. (I, 2)

An abstract good does not precede goodness. It is the actions of men, and their authority, which then allows them to deem themselves good. First comes the power dynamic—the physiological state of “powerful...highminded”—and from that superiority, the “good” is asserted. There is no merit in this picture of “good”: the noble are now justified to act how they would have acted anyway. Then, for a plebeian to feel guilty for not being “good” as the powerful have defined is by design. Hence, to say that Nietzsche wants people to adopt the powerful “good” (i.e. the weak’s “evil”) is to take for prescriptive a morality which is an *a posteriori* justification; that is, a justification for those who are already “moral”.

The attention on the doer as opposed to the deed questions the value of morality itself. Nietzsche is examining the morality which pushes people towards being “more good-natured, more prudent, more comfortable, more mediocre, more indifferent” (I, 12). Hence, this morality pushes against the people who do not act meekly. Nietzsche finds this absurd:

To demand of strength that it should *not* express itself as strength, that it should *not* be a desire to overcome, a desire to throw down, a desire to become master, a thirst for enemies and resistances and triumphs, is just as absurd as to demand of a weakness that it should express itself as strength. (I, 13)

To tell strength to choose weakness is absurd since it is asking for something to be what it is not. It is like telling a great football player to miss a goal on purpose. Nietzsche identifies the “subject” as an *a posteriori* construct: “there is no “being” behind doing, effecting, becoming; “the doer” is merely a fiction added to the deed—the deed is everything” (I, 13). Take our great football player: it is not the case that what leads to their identity is the following, “*I am a great football player, and to be great is to score goals, so I score goals*”. Rather, the scoring of the goals is everything; only then does greatness arise. The “doer”, the subject, does not precede the action; first comes the action, and then comes a construction of the subject: “*I score goals, thus I am a great football player*”. This occurred with the master morality mentioned above: first came the behavior of the powerful, then came their establishment of such behavior as good, noble. Then, is it not the case that all morality is a fiction in that it *a posteriori* justifies actions?

The series of continuing questions and arguments that for a second seem to be stopping points but actually lead to further questions is Nietzsche’s trademark. It is more telling about Nietzsche’s method and moral project to end such an investigation on a question: Nietzsche does not mark a motion from uncertainty to clarity, rather, the opposite. Yet, moving out of illusory

clarity can lead to much more fruitful uncertainty. We may now see the subtle hope in the ominous forewarning, “morality will gradually *perish* now” (III, 27).